

JAMES LOUGHLIN

UX Design Leader | Product Design | Design Operations
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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Design leader with 6+ years of product design experience building mission-critical B2B applications for the U.S. Air Force. Currently directing design strategy and operations for a portfolio of 18 designers, shipping user-centered software aligned with the National Defense Strategy. Combines deep expertise in design systems, user research, and cross-functional collaboration to translate complex operational requirements into intuitive, accessible digital experiences that drive measurable mission impact.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Kessel Run – United States Air Force

2022 – Present

Portfolio Design Lead, Targeting & Geo-Intel (T&G)

- Spearhead product design strategy for the T&G software portfolio, defining user experience vision and design ops processes that support operational missions across the entire Air Force enterprise.
- Manage 6 direct-report designers and mentor 12 additional designers across the product line, implementing career ladders and competency frameworks that improved team design-maturity scores by ~30%.
- Champion user advocacy by synthesizing qualitative research, user journey maps, and stakeholder interviews into prioritized UX roadmaps, reducing average task-completion time across key operational workflows.
- Architect and maintain a centralized design system—including component libraries, documentation, and research repositories—that eliminated redundant processes and cut new-designer onboarding time by ~40%.
- Orchestrate design rituals (critiques, design sprints, usability read-outs) and facilitate cross-functional alignment between product, engineering, and military stakeholders to accelerate delivery cadence.

Kessel Run – United States Air Force

2019 – 2022

Product Designer

- Led end-to-end UX design—from user research and persona development through wireframing, prototyping, and design handoff—for multiple cloud-native applications used by Air Force operators worldwide.
- Conducted usability testing, A/B experiments, and heuristic evaluations with low- and high-fidelity prototypes, increasing post-launch feature adoption and reducing user error rates.
- Developed application-level interaction patterns, responsive design standards, and information architecture guidelines that improved visual consistency across the USAF enterprise application suite.
- Facilitated Design Studios, risk-and-assumption mapping, and sprint planning sessions that strengthened cross-functional collaboration and reduced design-to-development handoff friction.

Hyland Software

2018 – 2019

Brainware Analyst – Lead

- Led diagnostic workflows and CRM integration customization for enterprise clients, authoring internal knowledge-base documentation that streamlined support processes and accelerated analyst onboarding.

Lexmark Enterprise Software

2014 – 2018

Professional Services Consultant

- Managed end-to-end solution research, design, and delivery of enterprise content management implementations, coordinating across client stakeholders and cross-functional technical teams.

SKILLS & EXPERTISE

Leadership & Strategy: Design Operations, Team Management, Stakeholder Management, Career Laddering, Design Critiques, Mentorship, Workshop Facilitation, Executive Communication

UX & Research: User-Centered Design, Design Thinking, Lean UX, Design Systems, Information Architecture, User Journey Mapping, User Personas, User Flows, Wireframing, Prototyping, Usability Testing, A/B Testing, Heuristic Evaluation, Accessibility (WCAG), Responsive Design, Data-Driven Design

Tools: Figma, Sketch, Miro, Mural, Lucid, Adobe Creative Cloud, Framer, Airtable, Material Design, Jira

Technical: HTML5/CSS, Git, Agile/Scrum, Machine Learning & Assistive Technology (working knowledge)

EDUCATION

University of Iowa — B.A. Journalism | B.S. Computer Informatics